kept changing, but the love with which they were made remained the same. The amount of love that we received from the people during the Yatra was beyond what I had ever imagined. What was most surprising for me was the manner in which children, the elderly and especially women came out in large numbers and hugged Rahul Gandhi. It seems incredible that a Yatra and a political leader can receive so much love from so many. But we did, and he did too.

And this makes me come to my third learning. Togetherness is key. It is only by building togetherness on the foundations of our connected ideas and mutual love that we can save the nation from hatred and build a better and just future for us all. And this is the idea that brings me back to why we undertook the Yatra. Now that I had already been part of the journey, I could clearly see that one of the most special things about the Yatra was that from the very beginning, it progressed naturally—it flowed. It is the positive outlook of the ideas and objectives of this Yatra that gave it this spontaneous flow. It is my belief that the power of love, non-violence, unity and courage gave strength to the Yatra.

Finally, as we entered the Kashmir Valley for the last leg of the Yatra, the positivity and feeling of togetherness also reaffirmed my commitment to the cause and to the people who had undertaken this journey with me. Despite several challenges and difficulties—political, geographical, organizational and personal—the Yatra had continued unabated. Be it because of the participation of the common people, the organizational strength of the Congress party in various states, Rahul Gandhi's personal capabilities, arrangements, security or the impact of the weather, the Yatra proved all scepticisms to be unfounded. History will decide if the Yatra is deemed a success or a failure, but those of us who walked in the Yatra know it has rekindled the flame of hope in people. The love and support that we all received demonstrated that it is only the Congress party that has and will continue to bring people together.

It is with these thoughts, lessons, realizations and memories that I found myself with all the yatris in the freshly snowed-in Kashmir Valley on the closing day. The closing speech by Rahul Gandhi in the middle of a